



JOSEPH ROBERTS, FIRST PRESIDENT OF LIBERIA

Union policy toward enslaved people in the rebellious states, including those who had escaped enslavement, wavered between decisive, proactive measures and lethargic inaction or neglect. Overall, the government was slow to implement a coherent policy. The Union Army, U.S. Treasury Department, various philanthropic organizations, the president, and Congress all got involved and had different, often competing proposals and procedures on how to deal with the great number of freedmen (freed slaves) or soon-to-be freedmen. Power ultimately rested with the military officers in any given area, and as early as the summer of 1861, Union commanders were confronted with large numbers of Black refugees who had run to safety within their lines.